

Organizational Systems — Module 08: Planning — Discussion Questions

20 unique questions on strategic planning, scenario analysis, resilience, and policy selection.

1. How does framing planning as "policy selection under expected free energy" differ from traditional strategic planning? What new options does this framing reveal?
2. What determines an organization's **temporal depth** — how far into the future it can meaningfully plan? How can temporal depth be extended?
3. Shell's scenario planning approach evaluates strategies against multiple futures. How does this compare to conventional forecasting? What are the advantages and limitations of each?
4. Why do most strategic plans fail? Reframe "plan failure" as an Active Inference problem — what specific inference or action errors typically occur?
5. What is the relationship between planning and uncertainty? Should organizations plan more or less when uncertainty is high?
6. Explain the **commitment-adaptability paradox**. Why can't organizations simply be "both committed and adaptable"? What structural solutions exist?
7. How does **resilience** differ from **efficiency**? Why do efficiency-maximizing organizations often have the lowest resilience?
8. What is the Active Inference interpretation of a "strategic hedge"? How does maintaining multiple options relate to expected free energy?
9. Scenario planning requires imagining futures that are uncomfortable (market collapse, competitor disruption). Why is this cognitively difficult for organizations, and how can it be facilitated?

10. How should the planning process differ for a startup (high uncertainty, limited resources) versus a Fortune 500 company (lower uncertainty, abundant resources)?
11. Evaluate your organization's most recent strategic plan against the "robustness tests" from the module. Does it address multiple scenarios? Define trigger signals? Balance exploration and exploitation?
12. Construct three simple scenarios for your industry over the next 5 years: (a) continuation of current trends, (b) significant disruption, (c) fundamental transformation. For each, describe the key drivers and implications for your organization.
13. Identify the **trigger signals** — specific observations that would tell you which of your scenarios is unfolding. How would you monitor these signals? Who would be responsible?
14. Your organization's strategic plan was created 18 months ago. Since then, the competitive landscape has changed significantly. Design a process for updating the plan that balances continuity (not changing everything) with responsiveness (incorporating new information).
15. Your board of directors asks for a "5-year plan" in an industry with 18-month product cycles. Using the temporal depth concept, propose an alternative planning framework that is more appropriate for your environment.
16. Design a resilience assessment for your organization. What specific capacities (absorptive, adaptive, transformative) would you evaluate? How would you test them without creating a real crisis?
17. Compare the planning approaches of two contrasting organizations: the military (detailed operational planning) and a venture capital firm (portfolio-based betting). What can corporate strategists learn from each?
18. How should an organization decide when to abandon a plan? What prediction errors should trigger a strategic pivot versus a minor adjustment?

19. Most organizations plan in annual cycles (annual budget, annual strategy review). Using Active Inference, evaluate this cadence. When is it appropriate, and when should planning be more frequent?
20. Nassim Taleb argues that organizations should be "antifragile" — actually getting stronger from shocks. Using the Active Inference framework, explain how an organization could design its planning system to be antifragile.